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Dear Editor of *Sustainability*,

I am writing to submit our manuscript entitled, “**Navigating the Polycrisis: Institutional Responses and Sustainable Cluster Resilience in China’s Traditional Textile Industry**,” for consideration as an Original Research Article in your esteemed journal, within the section related to Economic and Business Aspects of Sustainability.

In the current era of compounding environmental, trade, and technological shocks, traditional labor-intensive industrial clusters in developing economies face unprecedented existential threats. While the literature on Regional Economic Resilience (RER) has grown significantly, it often treats local institutional mechanisms as a “black box,” neglecting the micro-level transmission channels through which policy interventions translate into firm-level outcomes.

Our study addresses this gap through a 25-year (2000–2024) longitudinal mixed-methods case study of the Gaoyang towel cluster in China—the country’s largest towel production base, accounting for approximately one-third of national output. We introduce a novel conceptual distinction between *policy attention* (discursive emphasis in official documents) and *institutional supply* (actual resource allocation), and trace the micro-transmission mechanisms of *compliance cost socialization* (through centralized environmental infrastructure) and *transaction cost reduction* (through e-commerce and regional branding).

Key Contributions:

1. **Methodological Integration:** We combine BERTopic dynamic topic modeling with quasi-experimental causal inference (Synthetic Control Method and Interrupted Time Series) to provide a transparent mixed-methods template for policy evaluation. We openly disclose data constraints—including heterogeneity in archival document length—and adopt the three-pronged validation framework of Grimmer and Stewart (2013) for NLP construct validity.
2. **Conceptual Innovation:** We articulate a two-stage resilience trajectory—“baseline resilience” secured through compliance cost socialization, followed

by “value resilience” achieved through transaction cost reduction—grounded in a microeconomic formalization of firm cost structures.

3. **Honest Empirical Reporting:** We provide directionally consistent but statistically qualified evidence across SCM and ITS, explicitly characterizing our findings as *mechanism-illustrative* rather than *causal-confirmatory*, and enumerating limitations transparently to guide future research.

We believe our paper aligns with *Sustainability*’s interdisciplinary scope, contributing to the journal’s discourse on regional resilience, industrial policy, and sustainable development. The manuscript transparently acknowledges the limitations of single-case causal inference and offers a replicable template for mixed-methods policy evaluation under data constraints. All data and code supporting this study will be made openly available upon publication.

This manuscript is original, has not been published previously, and is not under consideration for publication elsewhere. All authors have approved the manuscript and agree with its submission to your journal. The authors declare no conflict of interest.

Thank you for your time and consideration. We look forward to your response.

Sincerely,

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